

carefully,” I said. “Until you know exactly where you stand financially, until you have a crystal-clear picture of your money situation—your flow in and out, your expenses, your savings, your investments, everything, and you consult an expert—you are to give away NO money. None. Not to your grandchildren, not to your siblings. Not a dime. Do you understand?”

She nodded, still fighting back tears. This woman needed someone reliable to go through her accounts and write up an intuitive financial plan that would be simple for her to follow and guarantee that her money would outlast her. I gave her my card and the number of a good friend of mine who was a rock-solid financial advisor, and I told her to stay in touch.

As I walked away, I wasn’t feeling very good about the exchange. I shuddered to think how easily it can all go wrong for someone who has no money sense, even when she has money. One tough market correction, one bad loan, one ill-advised investment, and all that money could disappear. Who would take care of this woman then?

The inspiration for this book came from that moment, a casual conversation on a street corner with someone in need asking me for help with her personal finances. Though people have always sought out my investment advice, I’ve never billed myself as a personal-finance expert. But I *am* a money expert. For that reason, this book is going to be different from other books that offer financial advice. This book isn’t just about money, but about your relationship with money. I’ve always believed that if you improve how you relate to money, you’ll have more of it. I’m going to show why that’s true, and how to build financial stability by thinking differently about your finances.

My goal is simple: to offer practical ways for you to save money, invest better, and cut your costs—at every stage in life, from cradle to grave. I’ll teach you how to raise money-savvy kids who don’t spend too much or get into debt too early. I’ll show you how young people can graduate with less debt and in better shape to pay off student loans. I’ll show you how to talk to your loved ones about money and how to make sure your romantic relationships, marriages, and partnerships don’t get overshadowed by debt, overspending, and financial concerns. I’ll help you avoid common mistakes people make